meeting with the prime minister a standard task in the pre-policy drill. These meetings were always one-on-one. One of Dr Manmohan Singh's strong qualities is that he is a good listener and I always found him eager to get the Reserve Bank's perspective on every macroeconomic issue. The fiscal situation would, of course, figure in our conversation and my tale of woe about how the fiscal stance of the government was undermining the Reserve Bank's anti-inflation position was standard fare. To his enormous credit, he never interfered in the policy action. 'I hope you've settled this with the finance minister' was all he'd say. I never felt comfortable about this bit of the conversation but I would nevertheless tell him of the finance minister's reservations, and the matter would rest there.

This quarterly conversation with the prime minister typically extended beyond macroeconomic issues. He once asked me, from out of the blue, if banks were functioning normally in extremist-affected areas. I was deeply embarrassed because it never occurred to me to probe this question. He was also given to seeking my views on political economy issues weighing on his mind such as, for example, allowing foreign direct investment in multi-brand retail, the land acquisition bill or expanding the employment guarantee scheme and even on issues that do not directly fall within the domain of the Reserve Bank such as the goods and services tax. My expertise on these issues was modest; but that did not stop me from masquerading as an expert and pontificating! He also looked upon me as an Andhra expert and would inquire about issues like agricultural distress, farmer suicides and the agitation for a separate Telangana. I had left Andhra Pradesh over fifteen years ago and could not keep abreast of all the developments there because of job pressures. Almost always, I felt inadequate in giving him any fresh insights.

On one occasion, sometime in mid-2010, the prime minister surprised me by asking why so many people in the government were airing views in the public on the Reserve Bank's monetary policy. This was at a time when virtually every Delhi policy mandarin, major or minor, was commenting on what the Reserve Bank ought to be doing. I had no answer for his question but I told him that this was certainly vitiating the already fraught